

# A BUSY EVENING

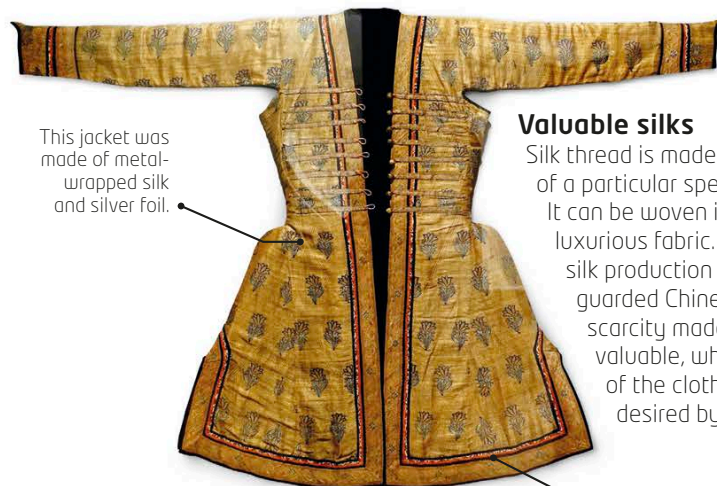
It is dusk at Izadkhast and the light is fading fast. Tired travelers are settling in, sheltering from the cold and unknown dangers of the desert. People have come from all over Asia, Africa, and Europe. They cook, eat, stable their animals, and organize their wares before going to bed, ahead of another long day's travel tomorrow.

## Ships of the desert

Along the deserts of the Silk Road, camels were the best form of transportation. They are strong, able to carry heavy loads of up to 496 lb (225 kg). Camels also cope well in dry conditions—they need much less water than horses, and their wide hooves stop them from sinking into the sand.



This figurine is loaded with Chinese pottery.



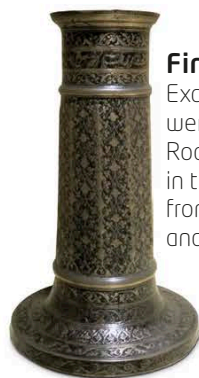
This jacket was made of metal-wrapped silk and silver foil.

## Valuable silks

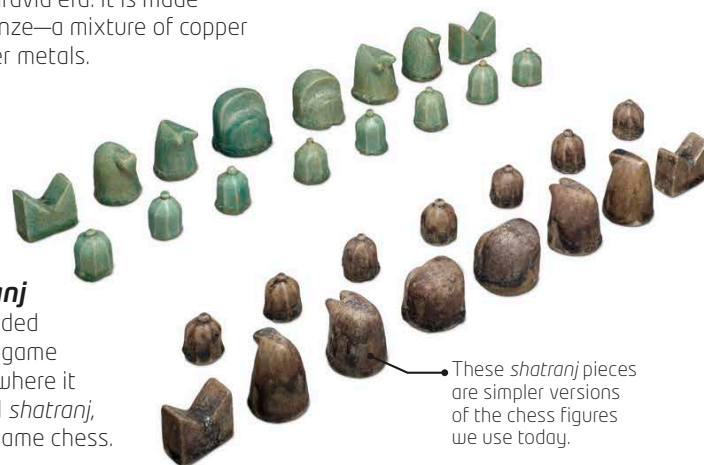
Silk thread is made from the cocoon of a particular species of moth. It can be woven into a soft, light, luxurious fabric. For a long time, silk production was a closely guarded Chinese secret. Its scarcity made it extremely valuable, while the beauty of the cloth meant it was desired by all who saw it.

## Fine metalwork

Exquisitely crafted metal goods were traded all along the Silk Road. This candlestick was made in the Safavid era. It is made from bronze—a mixture of copper and other metals.



The detail of the braid shows the skill of the Persian tailor who made the jacket.



These *shatranj* pieces are simpler versions of the chess figures we use today.

## 7 Evening prayers

Over by the fountain, a Muslim traveler kneels on a mat to begin his sunset prayer.

## 8 Silk for sale

A merchant's servant shakes the dust from a piece of silk his master wishes to sell.



**The game of *shatranj***  
It was not just goods that were traded along the Silk Road. The Indian game *chaturanga* traveled to Persia, where it developed into a game called *shatranj*, which eventually became chess.